

pieces *Scherzo fantastique* and *Feux d'artifice* (Fireworks), which he had heard at a concert in St. Petersburg in 1909—he therefore took a chance on Stravinsky, tasking him to complete the ballet in just five months—Stravinsky met the deadline. The Firebird's spectacularly successful premiere in Paris in May 1910 made him world-famous. The composer found himself rated as an equal by Debussy and Ravel, who were dazzled by his score's technical panache and orchestral mastery.

Immediately recommissioned by Diaghilev, Stravinsky came up a year later with *Petrushka*, a tale of fairground life, whose main character is a puppet with poignantly human feelings. Another success for its composer, the ballet also made a star of the great dancer Vaslav Nijinsky. Two years later, a third Stravinsky ballet, *The Rite of Spring*, totally rewrote the rules of what classical music could do, with its fiercely dissonant harmonic idiom and unprecedented rhythmic firepower. The famous first-night “riot” (more accurately a commotion by outraged Parisian ballet patrons in the theater's expensive seats) seems to have been sparked as much by Nijinsky's unconventional choreography as by Stravinsky's music, and was not repeated in the remaining five performances: Stravinsky's score met with increasing, if startled, admiration.